with ensuring Washington's commitment to "mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity [and] noninterference in each other's internal affairs."[4] In other words, give China what it needed to thrive but otherwise leave it alone.

Nixon's successors, while being careful not to stray too far from his guarded rhetoric, over time found it almost impossible to rein in their expectations about China, which were largely economic, while downplaying the obvious political and ideological differences between the countries. Successive American administrations dismissed warnings about China's potential strategic challenge in Asia and beyond, preferring to focus instead on a vision of Sino-American relations that was shared only by one side.[5] Not even the June 1989 Tiananmen Square massacre could significantly derail Washington's engagement with China, as the George H. W. Bush administration quickly moved to reopen high-level channels of communications after imposing limited sanctions and banning senior exchanges. Pundits and commentators followed the politicians' lead over the decades, making overly optimistic assumptions about how China would develop at home and act abroad.[6] These assumptions even now retain their tenacity, despite mountains of evidence that undermine them. Yet for the past several years, and not coincidentally since the election of Donald Trump as US president, the United States and the rest of the world are in the midst of a painful reconsideration of their relations with China. That reconsideration should begin with a clear understanding of how they came by their China dream.

A particular confluence of global factors abetted these rising American and global hopes in the decades after Nixon's visit. The first factor was the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 and the end of the Cold War, which seemed to many Americans proof of the final victory of liberal capitalist democracy. For many commentators, particularly conservative ones such as Charles Krauthammer and Francis Fukuyama, it was logical, if not inevitable, that other nations would adopt the Western model of social, political, and economic organization, what some called the "Washington consensus."[7] It would only make sense for